

ESSENTIAL

Financial Requirements Overview

Why your I-20's figure - not a government minimum - is what you evidence

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Your I-20's figure is the reference amount

There's no government-set minimum for an F-1 application - your own SEVP-approved school sets the annual cost figure on your I-20, combining tuition and an estimated living cost for that specific school and location. Your financial evidence needs to clearly cover that figure, not a generic national benchmark.

What matters in practice

- Evidence that clearly, credibly covers your I-20's stated annual figure
- A clear, traceable funding source - your own funds, a family sponsor, a scholarship, or an assistantship, or some combination
- If bringing F-2 dependents, evidence covering the additional per-dependent amount your school includes on the I-20

Acceptable evidence

- Personal or family bank statements covering a reasonable recent period
- A scholarship confirmation letter, for the amount and duration it covers
- A teaching/research assistantship offer letter, for graduate applicants
- A family sponsor's financial evidence and funding letter, for the portion they're covering

Red flags

- A large, recent, unexplained deposit shortly before applying
- Financial evidence that doesn't clearly match your I-20's stated figure
- Being unable to explain your own funding source clearly in the interview